

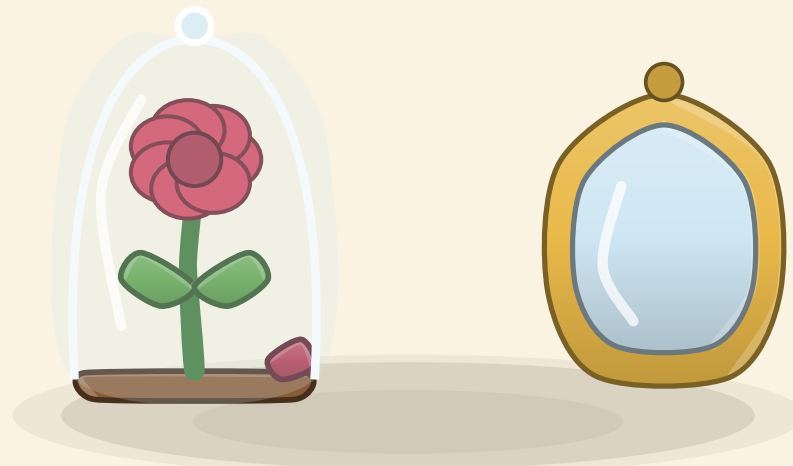
★ Beauty and the Beast ★

an old fairy tale, told again



Beauty and the Beast

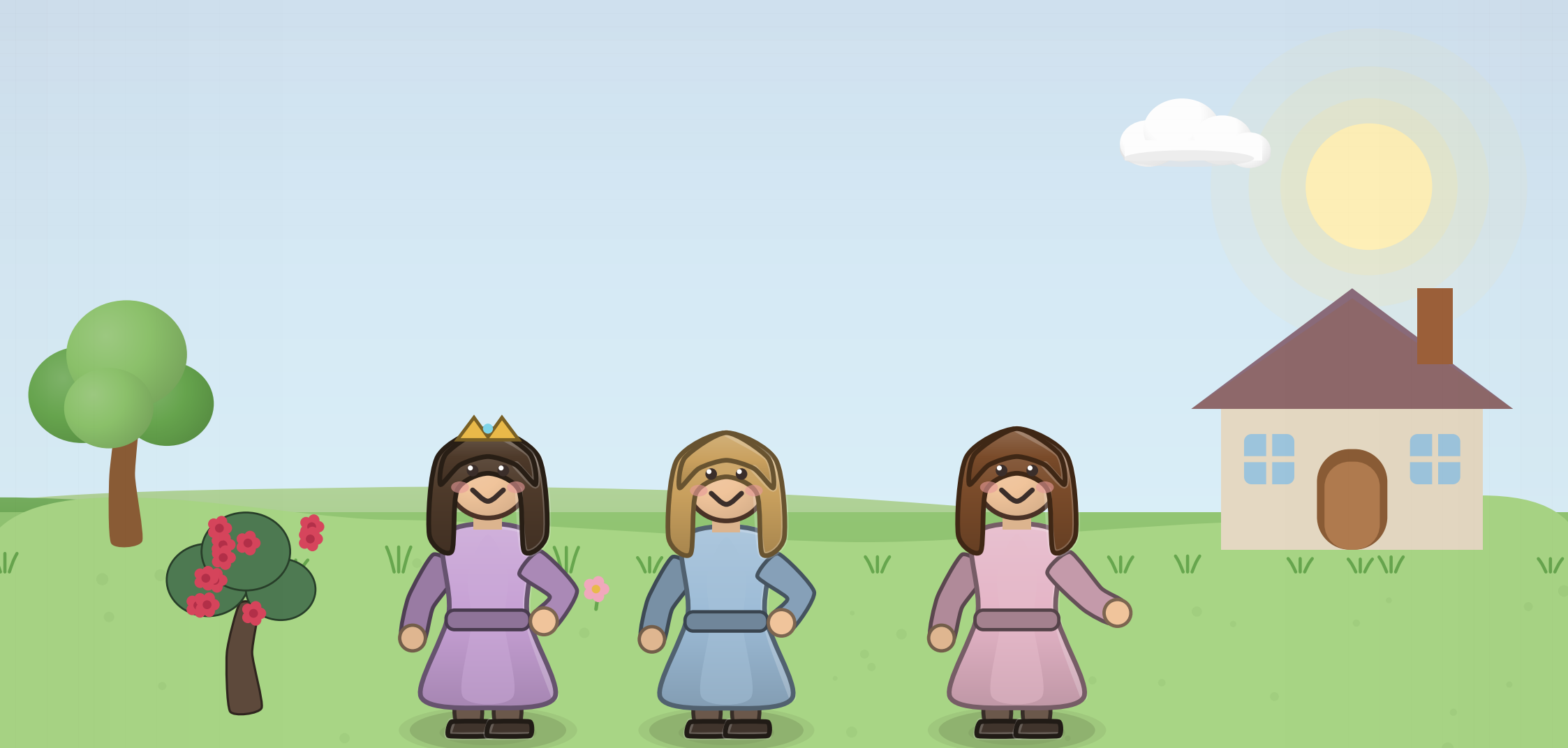
after Madame Leprince de Beaumont



This book belongs to

A retelling of “La Belle et la Bête”, published by Madame Leprince de Beaumont in 1756.

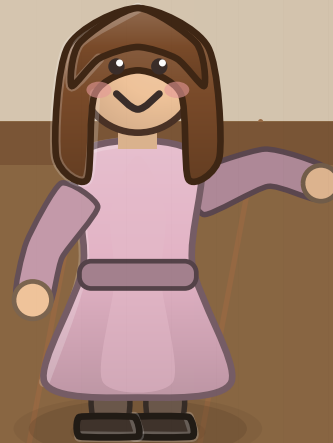
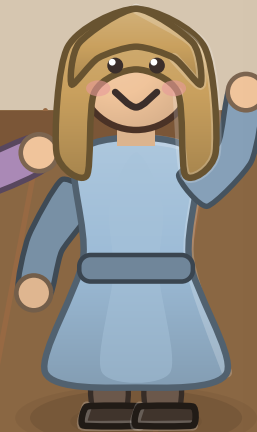
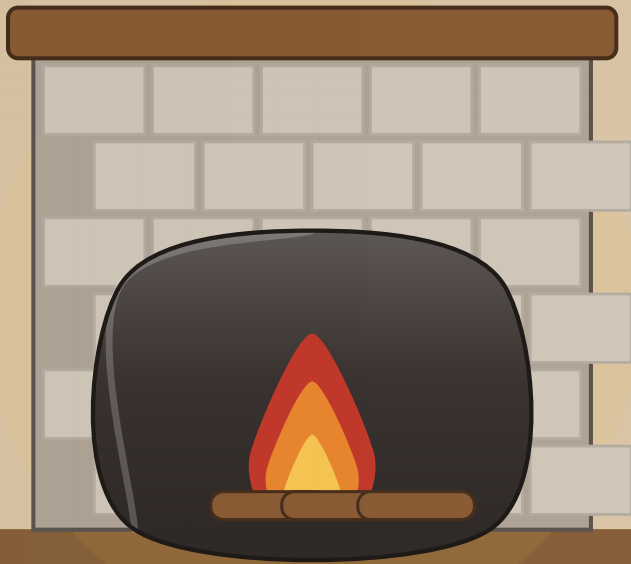
Illustrations drawn as vector art. Made to be read aloud.



A merchant had three daughters. The two eldest liked ribbons and mirrors and being agreed with.
The youngest liked books, and roses, and being out of doors — and everybody called her Beauty.



One winter the merchant's ships were lost at sea, and the family had to move to a small cold house at the edge of a wood.



When at last he had to travel again, he asked what he should bring back.
“A silk gown,” said the first. “A pearl comb,” said the second.
“One rose,” said Beauty. “I should like a rose.”



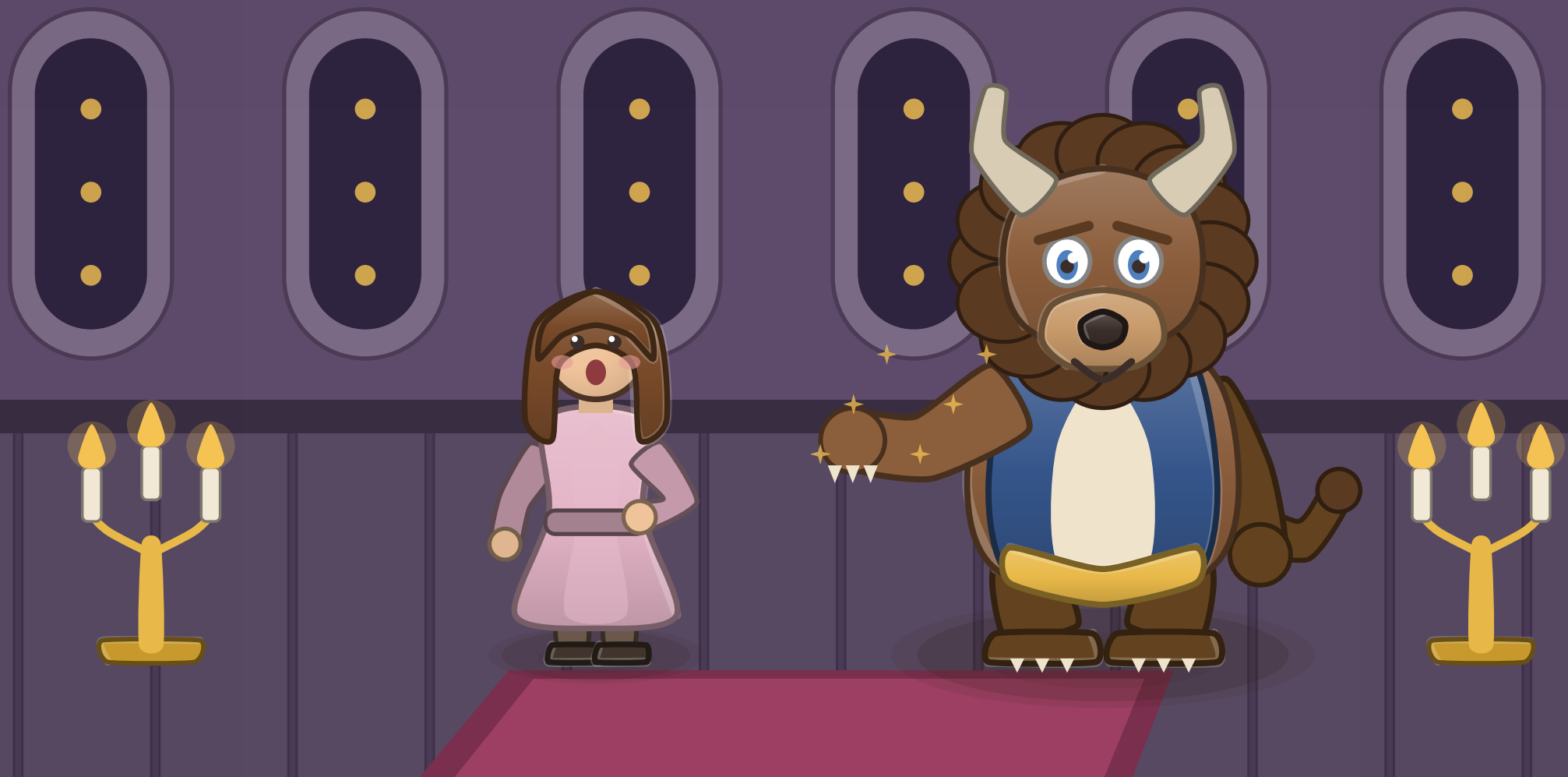
He found no fortune, and coming home in the snow he lost the road altogether. Between the trees stood a castle with every window lit. The doors opened by themselves. Supper was already laid.



In the morning he saw roses growing in the snow, and remembered his promise, and picked one.
A voice like thunder came out of the garden. “I gave you everything,” said the Beast, “and you take my rose?”



The merchant told him about Beauty, and about the promise.
The Beast was quiet for a long time. “Go home,” he said at last. “But someone must come back in your place.”



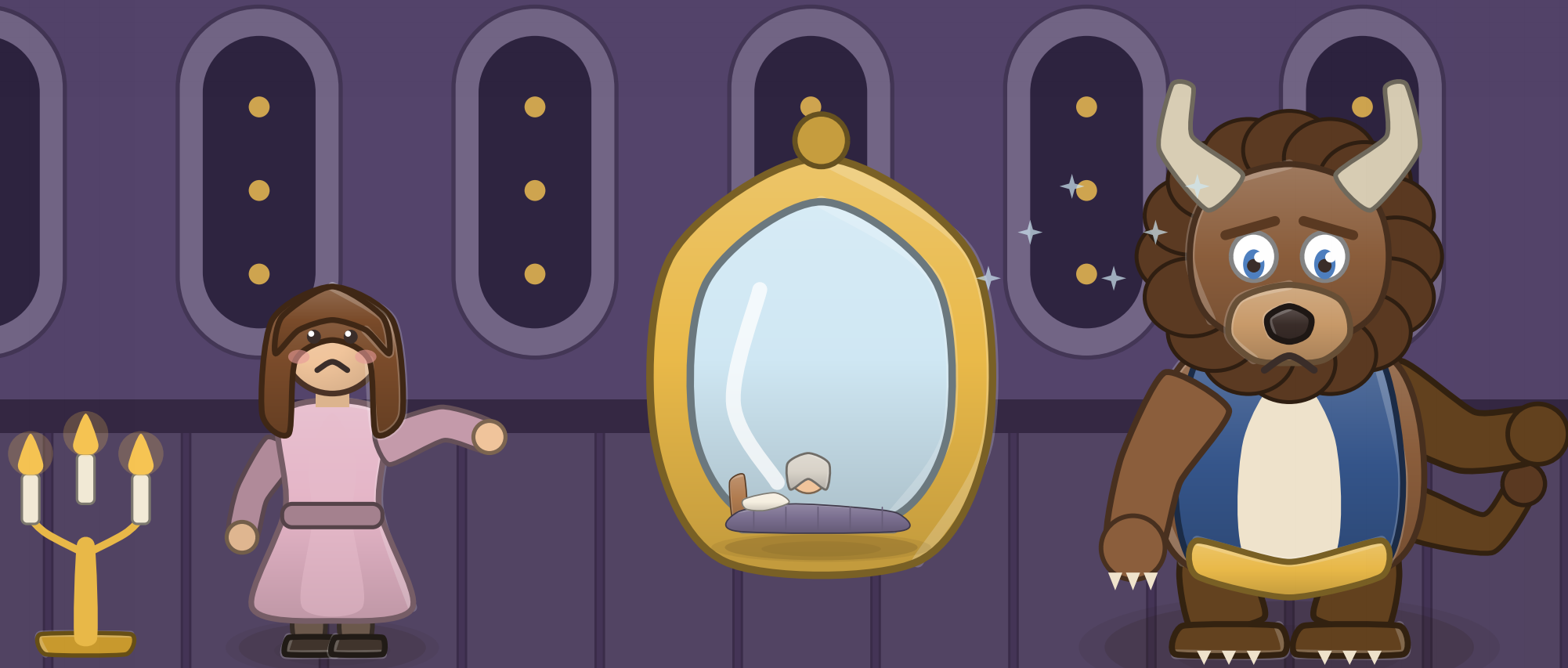
So Beauty came herself.
She was frightened of him — anybody would have been — but she curtsied all
the same, and the Beast bowed, which he had not done for a hundred years.



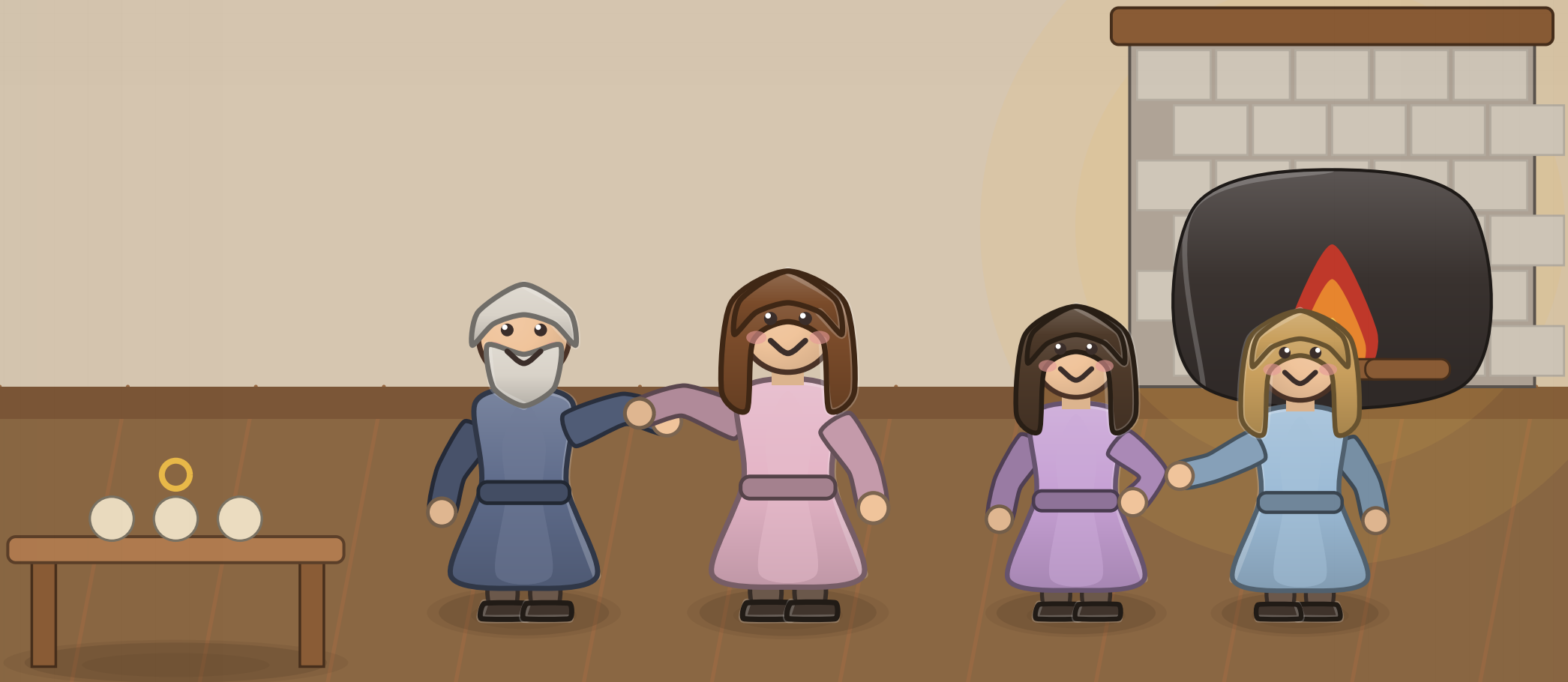
Every evening he asked her the same question: “Beauty, will you marry me?” And every evening she said, as kindly as she could, “No.” And he said, “Then goodnight,” and went away.



But the days were not unhappy. They walked in the garden. He showed her a library with every book anybody had ever written, and he listened when she read the good bits out loud.



One day, in a mirror, she saw her father lying ill.
“Go to him,” said the Beast. “Take this ring. Turn it when you wish to come back — only come back, or I shall die of it.”



At home everybody was so glad to see her that a week went by, and then another, and Beauty kept meaning to go and not going.



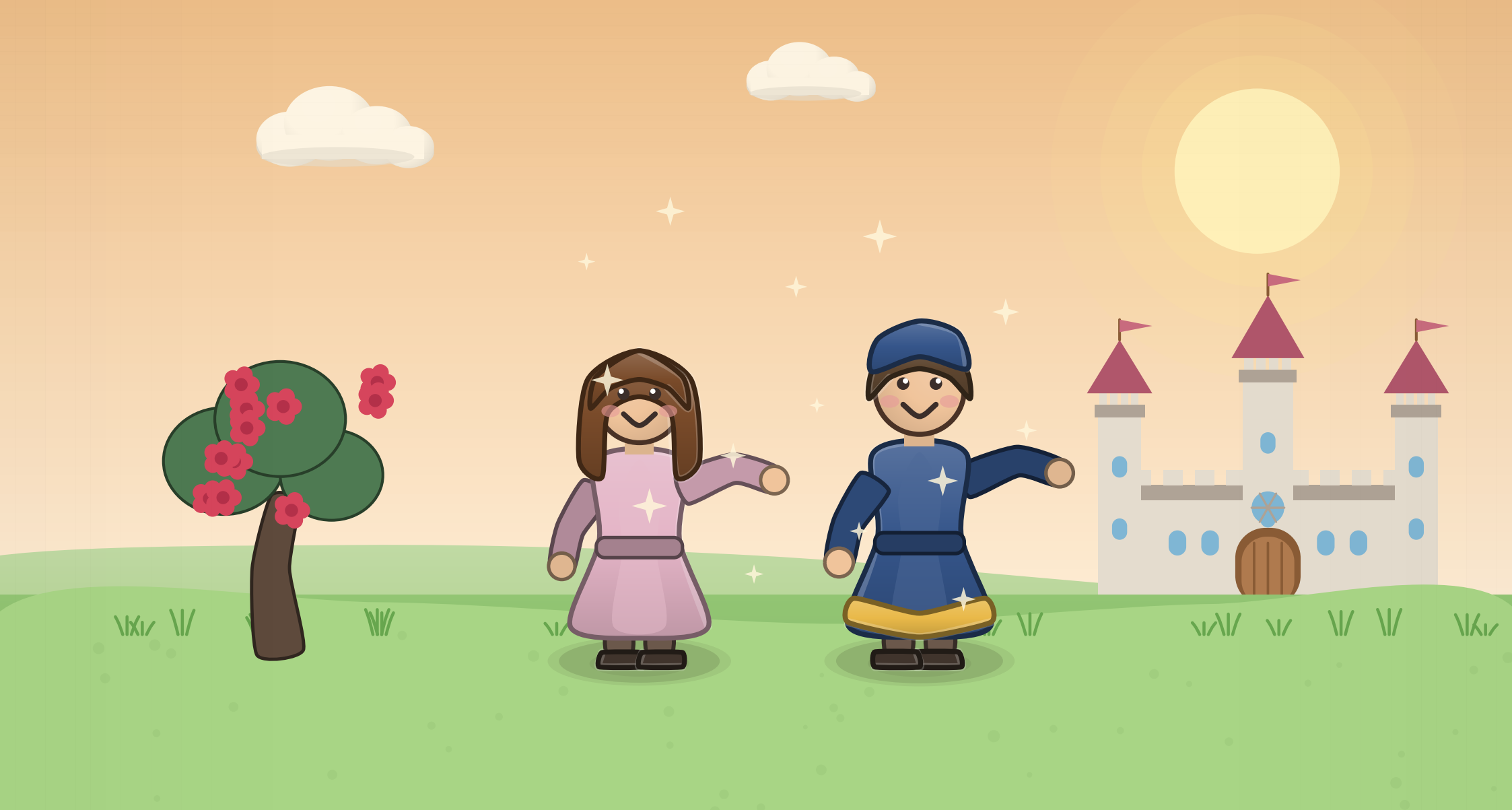
Then one night she dreamt of the Beast lying still in his own garden, under the
rose tree.

She woke, and turned the ring.



She found him exactly as she had dreamt, and knelt down in the wet grass and put her hand on his great head.

“Don't die,” she said. “I never knew until now — I love you.”



The garden filled with light.
And where the Beast had been there was a prince, blinking, who said: "That is
the kindest thing anyone has said to me in a hundred years."



The End

“I am not handsome,” said the Beast,
“but I do have a very good heart.”

